

Thoughts On Writing

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Academic Writing

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Overview

- 1 What is academic writing?
- 2 Some college admission application writing
- 3 Plagiarism and turnitin software

What is academic writing?

"Defined broadly as any writing done to fulfill a requirement of a college or university". Academic writing is also used to refer to written materials by researchers for **publications** or presentation at **academic conferences**. For publications, such materials will have to undergo **peer-review process**. A very broad definition of academic writing could include any writing assignment given in an academic setting:

- Research papers or research articles
- Essays
- Abstracts: short summaries of long documents
- Academic journals
- Dissertations and theses

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Academic writing

Type of academic text	Definition
Essay	A fairly short, self-contained argument, often using sources from a class in response to a question provided by an instructor.
Research paper	A more in-depth investigation based on independent research, often in response to a question chosen by the student.
Thesis/dissertation	The large final research project undertaken at the end of a degree, usually on a topic of the student's choice.
Research proposal	An outline of a potential topic and plan for a future dissertation or research project.
Literature review	A critical synthesis of existing research on a topic, usually written in order to inform the approach of a new piece of research.

Academic writing

Academic writing is...

- ✓ Formal and unbiased
- ✓ Clear and precise
- ✓ Focused and well-structured
- ✓ Well-sourced
- ✓ Correct and consistent

Academic writing is not...

- ✗ Personal
- ✗ Long-winded
- ✗ Emotive and grandiose

Academic writing

Ingredients in writing:

- Issue of plagiarism
- Mechanics [Grammar and consistency]
 - Writing numbers
 - Using abbreviations
 - American and British English [stick to one]
 - Font size and style/document format
- Be concise in your writing
- Avoid emotive and grandiose expressions
- 'Unless it is a personal experience', avoid use of first person voice
- Avoid being misunderstood in your writing
- Avoid use of jargon and big words

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Example college admission essay questions:

- In some schools and study programmes, the applicants are asked to submit general personal statements [statement of purposes]
- In others the applicants are given directions in what to include in their personal statements: "why the choice of the study programme and the school, how the choice of the programmes influences your career trajectory"
- In other schools and programmes, the applicants are asked to respond to specific application questions.
- Yet in some other schools and programmes, there are extra questions that seek to test the applicants leadership/non-academic skills

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How to answer select essay questions

Personal Statement of Educational Objectives: A personal statement describe your educational objectives. It address:

- Why you are applying for the program of choice,
- How your study programme of choice will relate to your long-range career objectives,
- What personal or “non-academic” qualities you will contribute to the learning environment in your program,
- What prior experience you have with respect to your chosen program, and
- Specifically why you want to attend the school/programme that you are applying to.

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How to answer an essay question

Interpreting a question:

Know the **5W1H** 'Who?', 'What?', 'When?', 'Where?', 'Why?', 'How?'

Just remember to always:

- Look out for the **key words** in the question
- **Outline** each key word in the question in your own words
- **Re-write** the question based on your outline
- Write the **key ideas** or **asks** of the question in dot points
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Sample general questions that you may encounter

- ① Describe a situation where you had to overcome a **significant obstacle/challenge(s)** to reach a **goal**. How did you **react** to this **challenge**, and what did you **learn** from this situation? [A general question among application essays in many schools...could be interesting to read about those who overcame the covid-19 adversity]
- ② Why should you, specifically, be considered for this financial aid? [A general question for those applying for financial aids/scholarships]
- ③ For International Students: What specific plan do you have, if any, for using the education you hope to receive? (0-50 words)[Harvard Supplemental essay question] item
- ④ What **service**, **innovation**, or **impact** have you already created/had for/ on your family, community, city, or country?

How to answer essay questions

Amherst College Supplement Essays 2017-2018:

Option A: Essay Response (300 words or less)

Please respond to one of the following quotations in an essay of not more than 300 words. It is not necessary to research, read, or refer to the texts from which these quotations are taken; we are looking for original, personal responses to these short excerpts. Remember that your essay should be personal in nature and not simply an argumentative essay.

"Difficulty need not foreshadow despair or defeat. Rather, achievement can be all the more satisfying because of obstacles surmounted."

How to Answer essay questions

- Describe an example of your leadership experience in which you have positively influenced others, helped resolve disputes or contributed to group efforts over time.[[University of California 2019-2020 Application Essay Question](#)]

When responding, things to consider:

- A leadership role can mean more than just a title. It can mean being a mentor to others, acting as the person in charge of a specific task, or taking the lead role in organizing an event or project. Think about what you accomplished and what you learned from the experience. What were your responsibilities?
- Did you lead a team? How did your experience change your perspective on leading others? Did you help to resolve an important dispute/problem at your school, church, in your community or an organization? And your leadership role does not necessarily have to be limited to school activities. For example, do you help out or take care of your family/community?

How to answer college essays

Describe how you have taken advantage of a significant educational opportunity or worked to overcome an educational barrier you have faced.

- An educational opportunity can be anything that has added value to your educational experience and better prepared you for college. For example, participation in an honors or academic enrichment program, or enrollment in an academy that's geared toward an occupation or a major, or taking advanced courses that interest you — just to name a few.
- If you choose to write about educational barriers you've faced, how did you overcome or strive to overcome them? What personal characteristics or skills did you call on to overcome this challenge? How did overcoming this barrier help shape who are you today?

Characteristics of academic writing

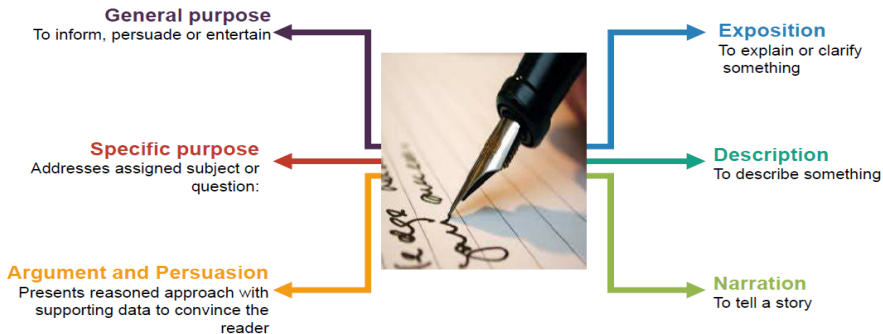
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What is the purpose of writing?



Academic writing

Type of academic text	Definition
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Academic writing: The rule

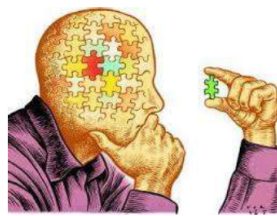
Academic Writing

- ✓ Academic writing is clear, concise and based on research – to increase knowledge
- ✓ Uses deductive reasoning, third person voice, and is more formal than some other types of writing



Use of deductive reasoning

Starting with a clear and direct argument (thesis statement) and argued using noted authorities in the field to prove the statement



Third-person point-of-view

Third person voice should be used. (*Use “The author believes” instead of “I think” and similar statements.*)

No first or second person references. (*“The reader must conclude” instead of “You should know.”*)



Writing objectively

Being **objective** suggests that you are concerned about **facts** and are not influenced by **personal feelings or biases**. Part of being objective is being **fair in your work**. Try to consider both sides of an argument and avoid making vague judgments. Being objective also makes your work more professional and credible¹.

Be explicit in expressing your ideas:

- several $\Rightarrow$ 11
- most of the population $\Rightarrow$ 70%
- some time ago $\Rightarrow$ three years ago; or in 2016

¹<https://owll.massey.ac.nz/academic-writing/writing-objectively.php>

Credibility in academic writing

Audience often makes judgments on how well supported your ideas or arguments are, and whether that support is valid, relevant, sufficient and convincing.

➤ Which of the following statements reads as most credible and convincing? Why?

1. Emotional intelligence is essential in the practice of management.
2. In my opinion emotional intelligence is essential in the practice of management.
3. According to Smith (1967) emotional intelligence is essential in the practice of management.
4. Jones (2004) argues that emotional intelligence is essential in the practice of management. In his view successful management practice hinges on effective communication between people, and emotional intelligence can contribute to that.

Formal language

Punctuation, proper grammar, and correct sentence structure are very important. A formal sentence you might see in an academic journal:

- Research has shown that learning a second language, in addition to leading to expanded career and social opportunities, can also expand the reasoning capability of the brain, although this finding is disputed by some scientists².

A less formal way to express the same idea:

- Learning another language can improve your career and social life. Some people also say it can make you smarter, but others disagree.

²<https://www.espressoenglish.net/formal-semi-formal-and-informal-english/>

Formality: Formal and impersonal language

Identify which expressions are too informal and personal

- A) When I look at the situation in emergency wards, with many staff leaving, it's hard not to worry about how many doctors will be available to treat patients in the future.

B) If we consider the situation in emergency wards, with increasingly low staff retention rates, there are concerns about the capacity of hospitals to maintain adequate doctor to patient ratios.
- A) It's so obvious that people were given jobs just because they were male or female. I don't think that is an acceptable approach and is even against the law.

B) It appears that in a number of instances jobs were assigned on the basis of gender. Given the current anti-discrimination laws, this raises serious concerns.

Idioms, slang & text speak

Idiom: The software is a piece of cake.

- The software is quite user-friendly.
- The software is extremely easy to use.

Slang: A million bucks in profit.

- A million dollars in profit.

Text speak: Tks & we look 4ward 2 meeting u.

- Thanks, and we look forward to meeting you.

Also avoid shortened words:

~~The info was incomplete.~~

The information was incomplete.

~~The results have arrived from the lab.~~

The results have arrived from the laboratory.

~~fruits and veggies~~

fruits and vegetables

Phrasal verbs and contractions

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Note the differences...

Extract 1

Across the globe, suicide is a serious public health issue (Mann et al., 2005). There are severe emotional costs for those affected by loss of acquaintance or loved ones in addition to significant economic costs through loss of income and medical treatment (Corso et al., 2007). In the last 45 years, worldwide suicide rates have increased by 60% (World Health Organisation, 2008). Consequently, the development of suicide prevention initiatives has become a global public health priority

Extract 2

Suicide is a serious problem. This is because if you lose somebody close to you, this can be very hard for you. It is also because suicide costs a lot of money to the economy to the losing members of the workforce and the cost of treating people who have attempted suicide. The number of people committing suicide has gone up a lot. It has gone up by 60% over the last 45 years. This means that people who work in public health all over the world need to come up with ideas that will prevent people from committing suicide.

Plagiarism

DO NOT DO THIS!

DO NOT DO THIS!

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Plagiarism

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Plagiarism

What are the differences between quoting, paraphrasing, and summarizing?

Quoting

- ✓ Must be in proper required format and style
- ✓ Must match source document word for word
- ✓ Must give attribution to original source and author
- ✓ Must provide supporting material
- ✓ Must have meaningful placement

Paraphrasing

- ✓ Must be in proper required format and style
- ✓ Paraphrasing is putting another person's words into your own
- ✓ Simplifies original source information
- ✓ Must give attribution to original source and author
- ✓ Must provide supporting material

Summarizing

- ✓ Simplifies and shortens original source main ideas
- ✓ Is in the authors own words
- ✓ Shortens the original work but retains original meaning
- ✓ Must give attribution to original source and author
- ✓ Must provide supporting material
- ✓ Must have meaningful placement

Is this plagiarism?

Original source

In order to communicate effectively with other people, one must have a reasonably accurate idea of what they do and do not know that is pertinent to the communication. Treating people as though they have knowledge that they do not have can result in miscommunication and perhaps embarrassment.

Nickerson, R. S. (1999). How we know - and sometimes misjudge - what others know: Imputing one's own knowledge to others. *Psychological Bulletin*, 125(6), 737-759.

Student's own work

Effective communication depends on a generally accurate knowledge of what the audience knows. If a speaker assumes too much knowledge about the subject, the audience will either misunderstand or be bewildered.

Is this plagiarism?

Original

In order to have a reasonable and pertinent knowledge perhaps

Nickerson and others know 125(6), 7

Student

Effective of what

knowledge about the subject, the audience will either misunderstand or be bewildered.

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Yes, this is plagiarism.

Although the student paraphrased from the original source, **a citation must be provided** in text and a reference at the end of their assignment.

e.g. ...or be bewildered (Nickerson, 1999).

Is this plagiarism?

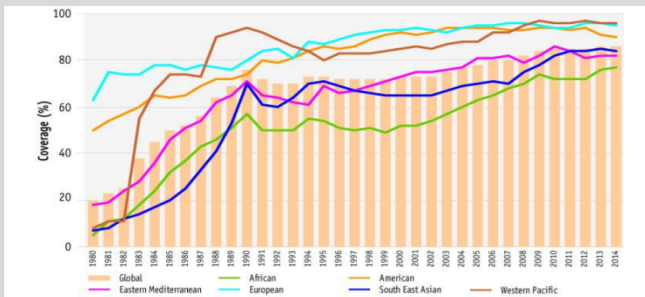
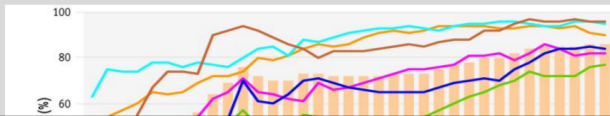


Figure 5. DTP3 % immunisation coverage (WHO, 2015).

Reference list

WHO. (2015). *Immunization*. Retrieved from:
www.who.int/gho/immunization/en/

Is this plagiarism?



No, not plagiarism.

As long as you provide a citation and a reference, you can reuse tables, diagrams and images.

Referen

WHO. (2015). *Immunization*. Retrieved from:
www.who.int/gho/immunization/en/

Is this plagiarism?

Article 1

Sometimes we have to write long papers, but most of the time, it is unnecessary: the papers often contain long introductions more suitable for doctoral dissertations or review “state of the art” papers apparently designed to provide evidence that the author is well-read.

Krashen, S. (2012). A short paper proposing that we need to write shorter papers. *Language and Language Teaching*, 1(2), 38-39.

Article 2

Sometimes we have to write long papers to treat a topic adequately, but much of the time, it's unnecessary: Papers often contain long introductions more suitable for doctoral dissertations, apparently intended to provide evidence that the author is well-read...

Krashen, S. (2013). Reading and vocabulary acquisition: Supporting Evidence and some objections. *Iranian Journal of Language Teaching Research*, 1(1), 27-43.

Is this plagiarism?

Article

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Article

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27-43.

Yes, this is self-plagiarism.

Even your own previously submitted work must be cited and referenced appropriately. You could either quote, paraphrase or summarise, providing a citation to the original source.

Check with your course leader for advice on how to handle your own previous works.

Plagiarism

Plagiarism is defined as presenting someone else's work as your own by:

- Cutting and pasting from other sources
- Quoting without "... " or a citation
- Paraphrasing or summarising without citation
- Using images, tables, or graphs without citation
- Re-using own work which was previously marked
- Collaborating on what should be individual work

Forgetting to cite is still plagiarism

Turnitin

Turnitin is a web-based tool for checking student work for plagiarism. When your work has been checked for plagiarism, a Turnitin score (sometimes called a Similarity index) and sometimes a Similarity report (if enabled) will be generated which tells you what percentage of your text matches text in the Turnitin database³.

³<https://owll.massey.ac.nz/referencing/turnitin.php>

Plagiarism

So you can be trapped?

ORIGINALITY REPORT			
36%	11%	17%	33%
SIMILARITY INDEX	INTERNET SOURCES	PUBLICATIONS	STUDENT PAPERS
PRIMARY SOURCES			
1	Submitted to Massey University Student Paper	18%	
2	Submitted to GradeGuru Publication	6%	
3	Submitted to Foothill College Student Paper	4%	
4	www.geography.csu.edu Internet Source	4%	
5	Submitted to CSU, Chico Student Paper	2%	
6	Submitted to South Birmingham College Student Paper	1%	
7	Submitted to University of College Cork Student Paper	1%	
8	Submitted to CSU, Fullerton Student Paper	1%	
9	nou.edu.ng Internet Source	<1%	

Body

- Humidity

Humidity refers to water vapour in the air. The capacity of air to hold water vapour is primarily a function of temperature. Warmer air has a greater capacity for holding water vapour than cooler air. The temperature at which a body of air becomes saturated is its dew-point temperature.

Relative humidity is a ratio of the amount of water vapour that is actually in the air, compared with the maximum water vapour the air could hold at a given temperature. If the air is saturated with all the moisture it can hold for its temperature, the relative humidity is 100%. A further increase of water vapour or a decrease in temperature results in active condensation. Relative humidity varies due to evaporation, condensation or temperature changes. All three affect both the moisture content and the capacity of the air to hold water vapour. It is highest at dawn, when air temperature is lowest and the capacity of air is less, and also lowest in late afternoon, where higher air temperatures increase the capacity of air to hold water vapour.

- Adiabatic Processes

o Adiabatic Warming and Cooling

In order for precipitation to occur, processes need to take place. Adiabatic processes are the changes in temperature that occur due to variations in the air pressure. When water

Reasons for plagiarism?

Why do you think that you might plagiarise?

I want better marks.

I'm not doing well in the module, I might fail.

The textbook explains it much better than I can.

I ran out of time, so it was quicker to copy bits and pieces from the internet

Nobody will know if I cheat.

Who cares? It was a stupid report anyway.

I'm not copying anyone else, just information from the internet.

**These are not reasons to plagiarise
– the consequences are serious**

Consequences of plagiarism

Consequences of Plagiarism. Students who plagiarize or otherwise engage in academic dishonesty face serious consequences. Sanctions may include, but are not limited to, failure on an assignment, grade reduction or course failure, suspension, and possibly dismissal

Harvard University

The consequences for academic dishonesty (cheating and plagiarism) are severe, but appropriate given that it constitutes stealing others' ideas and attempting to earn college credit for their work. Sanctions may include an RQ grade for the course, a permanent failing grade on your transcript, and suspension for 1 academic year^a.

^a<https://www.extension.harvard.edu/resources-policies/resources/avoiding-plagiarism>

Consequences of plagiarism

UC Berkeley

Students who submit plagiarized work will be subject to consequences ranging from a grade of "F" on the assignment to suspension from the University. For more on academic dishonesty and its consequences, see the Code of Student Conduct^a

^a<http://sa.berkeley.edu/student-code-of-conduct>

University of Pretoria

Students who commit plagiarism will not be given any credit for plagiarised work. The matter may also be referred to the Disciplinary Committee (Students) for a ruling. Plagiarism is regarded as a serious contravention of the University's rules and can lead to expulsion from the University. completed and submitted^a

^a<https://www.library.up.ac.za/plagiarism/index.htm>

END